visit to Moscow a year for consultations will suffice.’ [3] These and other factors persuaded Indira Gandhi and later Rajiv Gandhi to explore cooperation with the United States, even if some of those early proposals never fully materialized. In 1981, Indira Gandhi met Ronald Reagan in Mexico, and their convivial personal rapport translated into a visit by the prime minister to the United States the next year.

At the same time, Indira Gandhi continued her leading role in the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), hosting the group’s summit in 1983 that featured seventy heads of state, vice-presidents, and prime ministers. India had to manage the growing ideological fissures within NAM, which now encompassed Communist countries such as Cuba and conservative-leaning states in Asia, Africa, and Latin America. The Summit also had to negotiate on contentious questions such as the Soviet intervention in Afghanistan, the status of Cambodia and the Iran–Iraq war. [4]

In 1985, less than a year after assuming the prime ministership, Rajiv Gandhi visited Washington. In this instance, more momentum in India–US relations meant that cooperation with the United States went further, extending to a deal for jet engines for India’s indigenous fighter aircraft programme. Both Washington and New Delhi began discussions on more ambitious cooperation, extending to economic and security issues. Despite these developments, this attempt at balancing India’s relations between the superpowers in an era of Soviet *glasnost* and *perestroika* was limited by the ongoing proxy conflict in Afghanistan and the United States’ continued military support to Pakistan, among other factors. [5]

Bangladesh to Brasstacks: India and Pakistan, 1971–1988

The second striking feature of India’s foreign policy between 1971 and 1991 was its willingness to use force, albeit in a more geopolitically constrained region limited to South Asia and the Indian Ocean. This period witnessed a peaceful nuclear explosion (PNE), the annexation of Sikkim, military stand-offs with Pakistan and China, and interventions in Sri Lanka,